



larly, Indian clients ask for exotic dancers and gymnasts." Performance trends have also changed. Today exotic foreign folk dances, free-style performances, and at seedier events, even *mujras*, are in demand.

Though the fascination for white skin cannot be ruled out, Sabbas Joseph, director, Wizcraft, calls it the "uniqueness" package. "This includes costumes and dance routines, apart from their skin and hair colour," he says. "Their energy levels are higher than their Indian counterparts and they are a lot more uninhibited because they are not conscious about their bodies," says Joseph.

But many small-time coordinators refuse to comment, wary of the "prostitution racket" tag. Says a Bollywood insider on the condition of anonymity, "There are lots of Russian girls in

BENDABLE BEAUTIES: Dancers at a Men's Health event in Mumbai

Mumbai willing to do walk-on roles or party performances for a pittance, doubling up as escorts. They do have agents, but you can't always vouch for their professionalism."

Despite this, several have a connection with India that goes back to the love of Raj Kapoor movies. Like Xala, 26, a folk dancer from Uzbekistan, who received a scholarship from the Indian Council for Cultural Relations to train with the Kathak Kendra in Delhi in 2002. "The move to India seemed like the right choice," she says. Even on a student visa, she made the shift to Bollywood—money being a big incentive. But it wasn't easy. "Men think that if you're a foreigner, you are promiscuous and game for anything," she says. But marriage to Mullick has given her

a sense of security and she now works with an Indian troupe. Thirty five-year-old Nathalie—half Indian and Belgian—visited her grandparents in Goa, only to fall in love with an Iranian DJ and stay back. From selling clothes in a flea market she has now moved on to arranging foreigners for film songs. But she has been called many times by the police wanting to know whether her work also extends to supplying women for "pleasure".

It's a tag that the Russian women have learnt to ignore. As Bosco of film choreographers Bosco-Caesar puts it: "Foreign dancers add glamour to Bollywood. Indians don't have the height, look and skill for the stylised songs that big movies call for, so we have no choice but to look elsewhere." And while, ironically enough, the made-in-India *naach-gaana* is now being kept alive by foreign dancers on filmi sets, the next *Kajrare* rendition at your office party might also be delivered by a blonde Ukrainian. How's that for fair play?

"Men think that if you're a foreigner, you are game for anything. But my move to India was the right choice."

XALA, FOLK DANCER FROM UZBEKISTAN